

Case Comp Topic: How can ABA strategically expand and enhance its partnerships with colleges and universities to grow the academic partner network, and increase interest among college students in pursuing careers in banking?

Name: Ryan Rasske

Title: SVP, Risk and Customer Markets at ABA

- 1) Can you tell me about your career journey and what first drew you to the banking industry?

“Banking was not originally the path I had planned for myself. I actually started my career as a police officer and later worked with the Secret Service. My transition into banking came unexpectedly through networking. At an event, someone recognized that my background and skill set would translate well into fraud prevention and encouraged me to explore opportunities in banking at Etrade bank. That conversation opened the door to a career path I never initially considered but ultimately found incredibly rewarding.”

- 2) What has been the most rewarding part of working in banking?

“One of the most rewarding parts of my career has been the opportunity to lead and develop people. Managing large teams, helping employees grow, seeing them get promoted, and building a culture of collaboration has been extremely fulfilling. Through my work at ABA, I’ve also had the opportunity to influence and support financial institutions across the country, which has shown me the broader impact banking can have.”

- 3) What do you think is the biggest misconception college students have about careers in banking?

“A lot of students don’t realize how innovative banking has become. There is a misconception that banking is not as exciting or technology-focused as other industries, but that couldn’t be further from the truth. Banks are rapidly adopting technologies like artificial intelligence and finding new ways to solve problems. There is also a strong social impact side of banking that many students don’t see, from supporting communities through initiatives like the Community Reinvestment Act to efforts addressing issues like human trafficking.”

- 3) What do you wish more college students knew about the opportunities available in banking?

“ Banking is the heartbeat of business. For students who are ambitious and want to make an impact, there are incredible opportunities in this industry. A career in banking allows you to build financial knowledge and develop leadership skills.

- 4) Looking back, was there a person, experience, or opportunity that influenced your decision to pursue banking?

“ Throughout my career, I’ve been fortunate to have managers and mentors who left their fingerprint on my professional journey. They trusted me with opportunities to manage teams, give presentations, and grow outside of my comfort zone. At ABA, Richard Harvey was a mentor who gave me the opportunity to speak at a conference and helped me build connections that led to additional speaking opportunities. Those moments showed me the importance of having people who believe in your potential.”

- 5) If you could give one piece of advice to a college student considering a career in banking, what would it be?

“ People come into banking with different paths. As a college student finding your way into banking would be don't underestimate the power of your voice. Don't think you have power as a young professional but people are looking towards you for new ideas especially as new technology evolves. You can get rejected for ur input. From a professional standpoint it would be okay. Maybe that wasn't a great idea/input but let me shadow you and see what you do to learn. Asking to shadow is a great way to build a professional connection.”

Name: Russell Davis

Title: EVP, Member Experience at ABA

* Doesn't work specifically in banking, but still provides insight into misconceptions, advice, and banking industry *

- 1) Can you tell me about your career journey and what first drew you to the banking industry?

“ My career journey started in financial services, then moved into management consulting, and eventually into the membership organization space. My experience in financial services helped me understand how businesses operate and how different organizations create value for their members and customers. It gave me a unique perspective on how important relationships, partnerships, and communities are within the banking industry.”

2) What has been the most rewarding part of working in banking?

“ The most rewarding part of working in banking has always been the people. Banks are made up of individuals who care deeply about their teams, their customers, and the communities they serve. The work banks do has a real impact—not only in how businesses operate, but also in how people manage their financial lives and achieve their goals.”

3) What do you think is the biggest misconception college students have about careers in banking?

“ One of the biggest misconceptions is that you have to be a ‘math person’ to work in banking. While financial knowledge is important, the reality is that many roles in banking require a wide range of skills. In fact, a large majority of people working in banking are using skills like communication, problem-solving, relationship building.”

4) What do you wish more college students knew about the opportunities available in banking?

“ Many students don’t realize how rewarding and flexible a career in banking can be. Banking provides opportunities to build skills that apply across many industries, including working with customers, managing teams, solving business challenges, and building relationships. The skills you develop in banking can open doors throughout your career.”

5) What are some challenges in banking that you think college students or those entering the industry should be aware of?

“ Banking is ultimately a customer-focused business. Whether you are working directly with customers or supporting internal teams, having a strong customer mindset is essential. Banking is also a team sport—you have to collaborate effectively and work with people across different areas of an organization. The best bankers are those who understand the importance of teamwork and building strong relationships.”

6) Looking back, was there a person, experience, or opportunity that influenced your decision to pursue banking?

“ My career has given me the opportunity to work with hundreds of banks around the world, and one thing I’ve learned is that while every institution has its own unique characteristics, there are also many similarities. Seeing how different organizations operate and learning from the people within them has been one of the most rewarding parts of my journey.”

7) If you could give one piece of advice to a college student considering a career in banking, what would it be?

“ Go for it. Once you walk through the door of a bank, many more doors will open. Banks are complex organizations that need people with a wide range of skills and backgrounds. You may start in one area and discover opportunities in completely different parts of the organization. Banking offers the chance to continue learning, grow your skills, and build a career in many different directions.”